INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #51 · FORGIVING OTHERS

“If I forgive them, I'm saying what they did was okay.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

We often resist forgiveness because we fear it erases the wrong. If someone hurt us badly, forgiving can feel like letting them off the hook, minimizing our pain, or telling the world that their behavior is acceptable. Pressure from others to “just forgive” can strengthen the resistance.

What Scripture teaches

Jesus said, “If your brother sins, rebuke him; and if he repents, forgive him.” Forgiveness and rebuke go together, so forgiving is not saying it was okay. On the cross, Jesus prayed, “Father, forgive them, for they do not know what they are doing,” though what they did was terrible. Paul writes, “Do not avenge yourselves, beloved, but leave room for God’s wrath.” Forgiving means releasing the debt and leaving justice to God. It does not deny the wrong, and it does not require us to pretend.

> *“Watch yourselves. If your brother sins, rebuke him; and if he repents, forgive him. Even if he sins against you seven times in a day, and seven times returns to say, ‘I repent,’ you must forgive him”* (Luke 17:3–4).

Also see

> “Do not avenge yourselves, beloved, but leave room for God’s wrath. For it is written: ‘Vengeance is Mine; I will repay, says the Lord.’” (Romans 12:19).

> “Then Jesus said, ‘Father, forgive them, for they do not know what they are doing.’ And they divided up His garments by casting lots” (Luke 23:34).

> “Bear with one another and forgive any complaint you may have against someone else. Forgive as the Lord forgave you” (Colossians 3:13).

> “Be kind and tenderhearted to one another, forgiving each other just as in Christ God forgave you” (Ephesians 4:32).

Common self-statements

- Forgiving them means it did not matter.
- If I forgive, they win.
- They will think they got away with it.
- I would be dishonoring my pain.
- Forgiveness means excusing what they did.
- They have to answer for it first.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I must either excuse or hold a grudge.
- Catastrophizing: Imagining that forgiveness cancels all consequences.
- Mind reading: Assuming forgiveness will be taken as approval.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling that forgiveness is dishonest.

Challenging questions

- What exactly do I think forgiveness would mean?
- Can I name the wrong clearly and still forgive?
- What would it mean to leave justice to God?
- Did Jesus forgive without calling sin okay?
- What are the consequences or boundaries that can remain?
- What does holding on cost me?

Truth summary

> Forgiving does not say that what happened was okay. I can name the wrong, grieve it, and release the debt to God. Forgiveness frees me from bitterness; it does not erase accountability or require me to pretend.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Forgive
- Forgiveness
- Vengeance
- Hatred
- Anger

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Anger
- Communication

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Forgiveness — Matthew West
Ask God for help releasing resentment while working through real hurt.

Amazing Grace My Chains Are Gone — Chris Tomlin
Salvation and freedom come through grace rather than earning acceptance.

This Is Amazing Grace — Phil Wickham
Christ bears the burden of rescue rather than demanding self-salvation.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "If I forgive them, I'm saying what they did was okay"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If I forgive them, I'm saying what they did was okay." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What exactly happened?
- ☐ What does forgiveness mean to me?
- ☐ What can remain?
- ☐ What do I release to God?
- ☐ What does holding on cost?
- ☐ What boundary do I need?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Forgiveness is not approval.
- ☐ I can name the wrong and still forgive.
- ☐ Justice belongs to God.
- ☐ Jesus forgave while the wrong was real.
- ☐ Boundaries and consequences can remain.
- ☐ Forgiving frees me.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Luke 17:3–4**
  "Watch yourselves. If your brother sins, rebuke him; and if he repents, forgive him. Even if he sins against you seven times in a day, and seven times returns to say, 'I repent,' you must forgive him."
- ☐ **Romans 12:19**
  "Do not avenge yourselves, beloved, but leave room for God's wrath. For it is written: 'Vengeance is Mine; I will repay, says the Lord.'"
- ☐ **Luke 23:34**
  "Then Jesus said, 'Father, forgive them, for they do not know what they are doing.' And they divided up His garments by casting lots."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Naming and releasing: Each week, write what happened plainly and one step of releasing it to God.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Luke 17:3–4 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I can name the wrong and still release it to God.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Forgiveness" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ Write the wrong plainly. Describe what happened with no minimizing.
- ☐ Write what forgiveness is not. List the things you do not have to do.
- ☐ Hand it to God. Pray, "I release this debt to You."
- ☐ Set needed boundaries. Decide what limits will protect you.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If I forgive them, I'm saying what they did was okay": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Released to God
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If I forgive them, I'm saying what they did was okay.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, what happened was wrong. I bring it to You and release the debt. Give me freedom from bitterness without pretending, and leave justice with You. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #52 · FORGIVING OTHERS

“Forgiving means I have to trust them again.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Many believers were taught that real forgiveness means returning to how things were. In families, churches, and marriages, people are sometimes pressured to resume relationships with those who have not changed. That can lead us either to refuse forgiveness or to return to harm.

What Scripture teaches

Forgiveness and trust are different. Forgiveness is a gift we give; trust is something earned. Proverbs says, “The simple man believes every word, but the prudent man watches his steps.” Jesus told His disciples, “Be as shrewd as snakes and as innocent as doves.” He also said, “If he repents, forgive him,” which is about forgiveness, not about instantly resuming a close relationship. Paul writes, “If it is possible on your part, live at peace with everyone,” which acknowledges that peace is sometimes not possible. Where there is danger, safety must come first.

> *“The simple man believes every word, but the prudent man watches his steps”* (Proverbs 14:15).

Also see

> “Behold, I am sending you out like sheep among wolves; therefore be as shrewd as snakes and as innocent as doves” (Matthew 10:16).

> “Watch yourselves. If your brother sins, rebuke him; and if he repents, forgive him. Even if he sins against you seven times in a day, and seven times returns to say, ‘I repent,’ you must forgive him” (Luke 17:3–4).

> “If it is possible on your part, live at peace with everyone” (Romans 12:18).

> “Be kind and tenderhearted to one another, forgiving each other just as in Christ God forgave you” (Ephesians 4:32).

Common self-statements

- If I forgive, I have to let them back in.
- Forgiving means going back to normal.
- I cannot forgive because I cannot trust.
- If I keep my distance, I have not truly forgiven.
- I have to give another chance.
- I owe them access to me.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I must forgive and trust fully, or neither.
- Should statements: Insisting that I should return to the relationship.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that if I forgive, I will be hurt again.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling unsafe and concluding that I cannot forgive.

Challenging questions

- What is the difference between forgiveness and trust in my own words?
- Has the person changed, taken responsibility, and shown consistency?

- What conditions would make trust possible?
- What boundaries do I need to stay safe?
- Is there danger I need to take seriously?
- How can I forgive and still protect myself?

Truth summary

> I can forgive without trusting. Forgiveness releases the debt; trust is rebuilt over time through changed behavior. I can set wise boundaries, even limit contact, and still obey God in forgiving.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Forgiveness
- Trust
- Wisdom
- Protection
- Divorce

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Communication
- Anger

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Amazing Grace My Chains Are Gone — Chris Tomlin
Salvation and freedom come through grace rather than earning acceptance.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "Forgiving means I have to trust them again"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Forgiving means I have to trust them again." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What is the difference between forgiveness and trust?
- ☐ What would show change?
- ☐ What boundary do I need?
- ☐ Is there danger?
- ☐ Who can help?
- ☐ How can I forgive and stay safe?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Forgiveness is not the same as trust.
- ☐ Trust is earned by changed behavior.
- ☐ The prudent watch their steps.
- ☐ I can forgive and keep boundaries.
- ☐ Safety comes first.
- ☐ Peace is not always possible.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Proverbs 14:15**
  "The simple man believes every word, but the prudent man watches his steps."
- ☐ **Matthew 10:16**
  "Behold, I am sending you out like sheep among wolves; therefore be as shrewd as snakes and as innocent as doves."
- ☐ **Romans 12:18**
  "If it is possible on your part, live at peace with everyone."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Forgiven and protected: Each week, note one boundary that protects you and one release of resentment.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, Proverbs 14:15 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I can forgive and still be wise about trust.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Trust" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ List the difference. Write forgiveness on one side and trust on the other.
- ☐ Define the evidence. Write what changes would be needed to trust again.
- ☐ Set the boundary. Decide what contact is safe.
- ☐ Seek help if unsafe. If there is abuse, call 911 or the National Domestic Violence Hotline at 1-800-799-7233.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Forgiving means I have to trust them again": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Forgiven and protected
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Forgiving means I have to trust them again.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, help me forgive without putting myself at risk. Teach me wisdom about trust and give me courage to keep healthy boundaries. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #53 · FORGIVING OTHERS

“I can't forgive until I feel like forgiving.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

We assume forgiveness is an emotion, a warm feeling that arrives on its own. When the pain stays, we conclude we have not forgiven and may feel stuck or guilty. Waiting for the feeling can delay healing for years.

What Scripture teaches

Paul commands, “Bear with one another and forgive any complaint you may have against someone else. Forgive as the Lord forgave you.” Jesus said, “When you stand to pray, if you hold anything against another, forgive it.” Forgiveness is spoken of as a decision and an action. Feelings often follow, sometimes slowly. Jesus tells us to “love your enemies, do good to those who hate you, bless those who curse you, pray for those who mistreat you,” which are acts we can do before the feeling arrives. David prayed, “Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me.” We can ask God to change our hearts as we choose obedience.

> *“Bear with one another and forgive any complaint you may have against someone else. Forgive as the Lord forgave you”* (Colossians 3:13).

Also see

> “And when you stand to pray, if you hold anything against another, forgive it, so that your Father in heaven will forgive your trespasses as well” (Mark 11:25).

> “Be kind and tenderhearted to one another, forgiving each other just as in Christ God forgave you” (Ephesians 4:32).

> “Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me” (Psalm 51:10).

> “But to those of you who will listen, I say: Love your enemies, do good to those who hate you, bless those who curse you, pray for those who mistreat you” (Luke 6:27–28).

Common self-statements

- I do not feel forgiving, so I cannot.
- If it were real forgiveness, the pain would be gone.
- I am still angry, so I have not forgiven.
- I am waiting until my heart is ready.
- Forcing it would be fake.
- I cannot choose how I feel.

Common logical errors

- Emotional reasoning: Treating feelings as the measure of forgiveness.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing forgiveness is either complete or absent.
- Should statements: Insisting that I should feel peaceful first.
- Perfectionism: Expecting forgiveness to be complete in one step.

Challenging questions

- What is the difference between a decision to forgive and a feeling of forgiveness?
- What small action could I take that is consistent with forgiveness?

- Has a feeling ever followed a choice in other areas of my life?
- What am I waiting for before I start?
- How can I ask God to change my heart?
- Who can pray with me?

Truth summary

> Forgiveness begins as a decision, with feelings following over time. I can choose to release the debt, pray for the person, and ask God to change my heart. I do not have to wait for a feeling.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Forgiveness
- Forgive
- Prayer, How to
- Hatred
- Anger

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Anger
- Prayer

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Amazing Grace My Chains Are Gone — Chris Tomlin
Salvation and freedom come through grace rather than earning acceptance.

Forgiveness — Matthew West
Ask God for help releasing resentment while working through real hurt.

All Things New — Steven Curtis Chapman
God's renewing work offers hope beyond failure, decay, and loss.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "I can't forgive until I feel like forgiving"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I can't forgive until I feel like forgiving." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What is the decision I can make?
- ☐ What small act can I take?
- ☐ What am I waiting for?
- ☐ Whom can I pray for?
- ☐ Who can pray with me?
- ☐ How can I renew my choice?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Forgiveness is a decision.
- ☐ Feelings often follow choices.
- ☐ I can pray for those who hurt me.
- ☐ God can renew my heart.
- ☐ Forgiveness can be a process.
- ☐ I can start today.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Colossians 3:13
  "Bear with one another and forgive any complaint you may have against someone else. Forgive as the Lord forgave you."
- ☐ Mark 11:25
  "And when you stand to pray, if you hold anything against another, forgive it, so that your Father in heaven will forgive your trespasses as well."
- ☐ Psalm 51:10
  "Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me."

A verse I found myself: _____

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Choice and feeling: Each day, record one act of forgiveness (a prayer, a release) and any change in feeling.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Colossians 3:13 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I forgive as the Lord forgave me, even before the feeling comes.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Forgive" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Say the decision. Pray, "I choose to forgive [name], and I ask You to change my heart."
- [ ] Pray for them. Ask God to bless them for a week.
- [ ] Repeat as needed. Renew the decision when feelings flare up.
- [ ] Find a prayer partner. Ask a friend to pray with you.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I can't forgive until I feel like forgiving": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A choice made
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I can't forgive until I feel like forgiving.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I do not feel forgiving, but I choose to forgive. Create in me a clean heart, change my feelings in Your time, and help me release what I carry. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #54 · FORGIVING OTHERS

"They don't deserve to be forgiven."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

When harm is serious, it is natural to feel that the person has forfeited forgiveness, especially if they have shown no remorse. Our sense of justice is not wrong. But if forgiveness depends on deserving, it never comes, and we remain tied to the person by anger.

What Scripture teaches

Paul writes, "Be kind and tenderhearted to one another, forgiving each other just as in Christ God forgave you." "God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us." Micah says, "Who is a God like You, who pardons iniquity… because He delights in loving devotion?" Peter asked how often to forgive, and Jesus answered, "not just seven times, but seventy-seven times!" None of us deserved forgiveness. They may not deserve it, and neither did we. Forgiving does not mean they are innocent. It means we release them to God, who judges justly.

> *"Be kind and tenderhearted to one another, forgiving each other just as in Christ God forgave you"* (Ephesians 4:32).

Also see

> "But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us" (Romans 5:8).

> "Who is a God like You, who pardons iniquity and passes over the transgression of the remnant of His inheritance—who does not retain His anger forever, because He delights in loving devotion? He will again have compassion on us; He will vanquish our iniquities. You will cast out all our sins into the depths of the sea" (Micah 7:18–19).

> "Then Peter came to Jesus and asked, 'Lord, how many times shall I forgive my brother who sins against me? Up to seven times?' Jesus answered, 'I tell you, not just seven times, but seventy-seven times!'" (Matthew 18:21–22).

> "As far as the east is from the west, so far has He removed our transgressions from us" (Psalm 103:12).

Common self-statements

- What they did is unforgivable.
- They have not earned it.
- They are not sorry.
- They should suffer for what they did.
- Forgiving would be unfair.
- They do not deserve peace.

Common logical errors

- Should statements: Insisting that they must pay before I forgive.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing they either deserve forgiveness or not.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling righteous anger and concluding I should hold it.
- Magical thinking: Believing that holding resentment punishes them.

Challenging questions

- What do I think they deserve, and who is responsible for that?

- Does holding on to resentment hurt them or me?
- What did I deserve when Christ forgave me?
- What would it mean to hand them over to God?
- What does justice look like, and who delivers it?
- What would I gain by releasing it?

Truth summary

> They may not deserve forgiveness, and neither did I. Forgiving them does not make them innocent. It releases them to God's justice and frees me from the weight of resentment.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Forgiveness
- Forgive
- Vengeance
- Mercy
- Hatred

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Anger
- Communication

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

This Is Amazing Grace — Phil Wickham
Christ bears the burden of rescue rather than demanding self-salvation.

Forgiveness — Matthew West
Ask God for help releasing resentment while working through real hurt.

Amazing Grace My Chains Are Gone — Chris Tomlin
Salvation and freedom come through grace rather than earning acceptance.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "They don't deserve to be forgiven"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"They don't deserve to be forgiven." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What do I think they deserve?
- ☐ What did I deserve?
- ☐ Who judges?
- ☐ What does holding on cost?
- ☐ What would releasing give me?
- ☐ What support do I need?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Forgiveness is a gift, not a wage.
- ☐ Christ forgave me while I was a sinner.
- ☐ God pardons iniquity.
- ☐ Justice belongs to God.
- ☐ Resentment does not punish them.
- ☐ Forgiving frees me.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Ephesians 4:32
  "Be kind and tenderhearted to one another, forgiving each other just as in Christ God forgave you."
- ☐ Romans 5:8
  "But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us."
- ☐ Micah 7:18–19
  "Who is a God like You, who pardons iniquity and passes over the transgression of the remnant of His inheritance— who does not retain His anger forever, because He delights in loving devotion? He will again have compassion on us; He will vanquish our iniquities. You will cast out all our sins into the depths of the sea."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Gift, not wage: Each week, note one way holding on cost you and one way you released.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Ephesians 4:32 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I forgive as God forgave me, though I did not deserve it either.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Mercy" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Write what they owe. Write the debt you feel is owed.
- [ ] Compare to your forgiveness. Write how Christ treated your debt.
- [ ] Release the debt in prayer. Tell God you entrust justice to Him.
- [ ] Seek accountability where appropriate. If crimes occurred, involve authorities and safe support.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "They don't deserve to be forgiven": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Debt released
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~They don't deserve to be forgiven.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, they do not deserve it, and neither did I. Thank You for forgiving me. Help me release this debt to You, trusting You to judge justly. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #55 · FORGIVING OTHERS

“I'm a poor Christian because I can't forgive.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

When we hear that Christians must forgive, and we cannot, guilt can pile on top of the original hurt. Some of us have tried and failed, been told to “just let it go,” or hear sermons that make forgiveness sound easy. We conclude that our faith is defective.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture says, “He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust.” “A bruised reed He will not break and a smoldering wick He will not extinguish.” Paul writes, “Forgetting what is behind and straining toward what is ahead, I press on,” describing growth as a process, not an instant arrival. Peter himself asked how many times to forgive, which shows that forgiveness is hard even for disciples. David prayed, “Create in me a clean heart, O God.” Struggling to forgive means you are in the middle of a hard thing, not that you have failed at faith. “There is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus.”

> *“Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me”* (Psalm 51:10).

Also see

> “A bruised reed He will not break and a smoldering wick He will not extinguish; He will faithfully bring forth justice” (Isaiah 42:3).

> “Brothers, I do not consider myself yet to have taken hold of it. But one thing I do: Forgetting what is behind and straining toward what is ahead” (Philippians 3:13).

> “Then Peter came to Jesus and asked, ‘Lord, how many times shall I forgive my brother who sins against me? Up to seven times?’ Jesus answered, ‘I tell you, not just seven times, but seventy-seven times!’” (Matthew 18:21–22).

> “Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus” (Romans 8:1).

Common self-statements

- A real Christian would have forgiven by now.
- Something is wrong with my faith.
- God is disappointed in me.
- Others forgive more easily.
- I am failing God.
- I should be over this.

Common logical errors

- Should statements: Insisting that I should have forgiven already.
- Labeling: Calling myself a poor Christian.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I either forgave fully or failed.
- Social comparison: Comparing my process with others’ apparent ease.

Challenging questions

- What makes this hurt so hard to release?

- Is difficulty the same as failure?
- What steps have I already taken toward forgiveness?
- How does God treat me when I struggle?
- Who can walk with me through this?
- What honest prayer could I pray today?

Truth summary

> Struggling to forgive does not make me a poor Christian. God knows I am dust and does not break a bruised reed. Forgiveness is often a process, and I can keep taking honest steps with His help.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Forgiveness
- Forgive
- Guilt/Shame
- Mercy
- Weakness

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Anger
- Self-Esteem, Low

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Worn — Tenth Avenue North
Weariness can be expressed honestly while asking God for restoration.

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

This Is Amazing Grace — Phil Wickham
Christ bears the burden of rescue rather than demanding self-salvation.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I'm a poor Christian because I can't forgive"

✦ ✦ ✦

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Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I'm a poor Christian because I can't forgive." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What makes this hard?
- ☐ What steps have I taken?
- ☐ How does God treat me?
- ☐ Who can help?
- ☐ What can I pray honestly?
- ☐ What is my next step?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God knows I am dust.
- ☐ He does not break a bruised reed.
- ☐ Forgiveness can be a process.
- ☐ There is no condemnation for me.
- ☐ I can keep taking steps.
- ☐ He can create a clean heart in me.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 51:10
  "Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me."
- ☐ Isaiah 42:3
  "A bruised reed He will not break and a smoldering wick He will not extinguish; He will faithfully bring forth justice."
- ☐ Romans 8:1
  "Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

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  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Steps toward: Each week, record one step toward forgiveness, however small.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 51:10 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Create in me a clean heart, O God.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Forgiveness" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ Name the difficulty. Write what makes forgiveness hard.
- ☐ Pray honestly. Tell God you are struggling and ask for help.
- ☐ Take one small step. Pray for the person once, or write a letter you do not send.
- ☐ Get support. Talk with a counselor or pastor about the process.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I'm a poor Christian because I can't forgive": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A step toward
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I'm a poor Christian because I can't forgive.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, forgiving is hard for me. Thank You that You do not break the bruised reed. Create in me a clean heart, and help me take the next step, however small. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.